

Response Paper

Yanni A. Loukissas (2017) & Sylvia Janicki / Yanni A. Loukissas (2025)

Both texts challenge the assumption that data is a universal, objective, and context-independent phenomenon, revealing instead that data is always rooted in specific local conditions and contexts. Loukissas (2017) argues that Big Data is not a homogeneous or uniform whole but rather a heterogeneous aggregate composed of diverse local datasets, and proposes a "local reading" method to uncover the historical and institutional dynamics behind their production. Janicki and Loukissas (2025), on the other hand, carry the concept of "local" beyond the institutional scale and situate it within a bodily and affective dimension; through the practice of "local data memoirs," they examine how environmental data transforms our personal orientations and the emotional relationships we form with place.

The fundamental conceptual ground where the two frameworks converge is this: data is not a neutral means of representation but a dynamic actor continuously reshaped by human experience and agency. Nevertheless, a deep tension exists between the two texts in terms of methodology and scale. The 2017 text offers a macro-scale critique aimed at analytically dismantling massive institutional datasets such as those of the DPLA or Zillow, and at reading errors and absences in the data as traces of local context. The 2025 text, by contrast, adopts a micro-scale approach that prioritizes generativity and participation over critique; researchers do not merely analyze existing data but transform it into tangible objects such as mold jars or toy ducksturning it into a tool for emotional reorientation. This gives rise to a telling conceptual contrast: the first text positions the locality embedded in data as an advocacy tool for exposing institutional inequalities and political issues such as gentrification, while the second risks reducing structural environmental crises to an individual and psychological coping practice.

These differences and tensions raise three fundamental critical questions. First: if the practice of "local reading" requires institutional expertise to decode patterns and hidden errors in data, how can ordinary citizens effectively deploy this method as an advocacy tool against highly opaque and algorithmic platforms like Zillow? Second: can the deep personal acceptance and emotional reorientation afforded by "local data memoirs" be combined with the "counter-data" production articulated in the 2017 text to lay the groundwork for systemic political action or is this practice inherently confined to a form of inward, self-contained therapy? Third: while both approaches place considerable emphasis on the local in the production of meaning, could this micro-focus risk obscuring the broader structural and systemic forces that generate data in the first place, such as the climate crisis or global capitalism?

Ultimately, the most fundamental analytical lesson to be drawn from a combined reading of these two texts is this: to think locally is to think critically. Whether we are examining a vast digital archive or measuring toxic mold levels in our own homes, data

are never pure and independent realities they are traces that carry the history of the bodies, institutions, and infrastructures that produce them. To resist the top-down and universalizing narratives of Big Data, we must use the tools these two texts offer in conjunction: analytically deconstructing massive datasets while simultaneously producing personal counter-data that transforms abstract numbers into lived, bodily realities and in doing so, redefining our relationship with both the world and the technologies that mediate it.

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